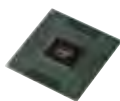




SSD good or bad

Despite their very high read and high write performance scores SSDs are still not as reliable as hard drives and when heavily fragmented their performance drops drastically



Intel ULV CPUs

An acronym for ultra low voltage, Intel's ULVs are the latest darling of compact, slim, netbook-like notebooks. They offer reduced performance with extra battery life

Laptop test

resolution like 1440 x 900 pixels, but a measly 1366 x 768 pixels is all you get. The screen has good brightness levels and great colour. Viewing angles are better than the Y550. The outer lid of the Y650 is textured and looks classy while the inside is a shockingly attractive pearl white. A media centre remote unit and built in TV tuner adds to the package. All in all a very feature rich, powerful solution that is lightweight and slim despite its large screen. Speaker quality is very good (for a laptop) and the bass is pretty decent. The price will make you flinch – Rs. 1,03,990 – pretty steep and in our opinion a little hard to justify, the carbon fibre notwithstanding. For this reason alone the Dell Studio XPS 1640 gets the nod ahead of the Y650 – its more powerful, and costs less with the configuration we received amounting to Rs. 65,900 without taxes, add another Rs. 7,000 to 12,000 depending on which part of India you reside in. Of course the Studio XPS 1640 can be configured to cost well over a lakh with suitably powerful components – it all depends on what you want. It wins our *Best Buy* award for its blend of style, performance and features.

GAMING NOTEBOOKS: Identity Crisis? Crisis Wars?

The term 'gaming notebook' is kind of paradoxical simply because in our opinion gaming on a notebook is somewhat of a neutered thrill compared to the full experience of gaming on a high-end PC. After all, what can replace a fast Core i7 processor, GeForce GTX 285 and 27-inch LCD monitor? – Nothing really, not even a PS3 or an X360, and if you're a hardcore computer-based gamer not even a gaming notebook. Obviously there is a downfall – lugging around a huge cabinet, LCD monitor and other paraphernalia is not everyone's cup of tea. Portability matters to many people and LAN-party goers will give up processing grunt for something smaller. Enter

the gaming laptop – a rare breed but one that is slowly catching on in India. Obviously a gaming notebook needs to be powerful in every way since modern games are the most demanding applications available so if a notebook can play games well, it'll surely do other software without even breaking a sweat.

MSI GX620X

Gaming on a budget

MSI's GX620X comes. Decked in fire engine red (on the lid



MSI GX620X

and the outer trim) and brushed black aluminium on the palmrest; this is one good-looking bad boy. It's heavy and owing to the all-metal lid feels extremely sturdy. This colour scheme is much better than ASUS' colour scheme that involves orange – not the most attractive of colours though it sure looks loud. The GX620X doesn't, rather it manages to convey an air of class. It's reasonably slim for a gaming notebook and looks sleek from all angles. The lid has a magnetic closing assembly that clicks shut with a nice positive feel. The touch buttons look a little too bright but work well. There is a touch key for selecting between eco

and turbo mode. The screen resolution is a little low for a notebook in this category, we'd like a resolution of 1440 x 900 pixels for this screen size but all we got was 1280 x 800 pixels. The trackpad although smooth imparts a very sticky feel to ones fingers and this prevents comfortable use. The keypad is well laid out though and works well.

When it comes to performance especially gaming performance the GX620X is not exactly a heavy hitter, obviously because all it has under the hood is a GeForce 9600GT and we're sorry to say that NVIDIA's mobility versions of their desktop GPUs are not as powerful. Of course this is also the case with ATI – those of you who think the same GPU in desktop and notebook avatars will offer similar performance, think again. So while you will be able to play most games forget about the latest games like *Crysis*

and *Clear Sky* – especially if you like playing at higher resolutions. Priced at Rs. 73,000 the MSI GX620X is a powerful gaming notebook for those looking for playing slightly older, less taxing games at LAN parties and it is reasonably portable. However, if you are looking to play the latest games at high resolutions please ignore this notebook.

ASUS G50V

Can I play too?

At first glance this looks a little weird with its orange bodywork. However, the body is sculpted well and colour



ASUS G50V

